# Deference-Based Solidarity

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Abstract:

Hannon (2025) argues that deference to marginalized voices cannot ground political solidarity because it fails to generate the moral understanding required for durable collective action. This paper grants that moral understanding can deepen and stabilize movements, but rejects the claim that it must precede solidarity. Drawing on the history of ACT UP! during the AIDS crisis, I develop an alternative picture in which deference functions not as an epistemic failure, but as a practical scaffold—enabling coordination and action under conditions of urgency, disagreement, and partial understanding. ACT UP!'s success, achieved without a unified moral framework or shared theoretical commitments, suggests that solidarity can form through action itself, with moral understanding emerging retrospectively through collective struggle. This praxis-first model challenges the idea that agents must first secure reflective moral agreement before acting. Instead, it demonstrates how deference can catalyze political momentum and generate the very understanding Hannon treats as a prerequisite.

## I. Introduction

Standpoint epistemology is having a moment again, though whether that moment feels like a revival or a reckoning depends on who you ask. One of the questions at stake is familiar and still unsettled: Can solidarity be grounded on deference to the marginalized?

Classically, standpoint epistemology says yes. Standpoint theorists argue that deference to marginalized standpoints is warranted because marginalized social positions can provide an epistemic advantage. On the other hand, recent papers by Tilton & Toole (2026), Taiwo (2023), Hannon (2025) disagree. Here for brevity, I'll focus just on Hannon's objection. He claims that even if deference is sometimes appropriate, it cannot provide what solidarity demands: moral understanding.

Hannon's argument unfolds in two steps. First, he objects to strong versions of the epistemic advantage thesis: if understanding comes in degrees (which he takes to be largely uncontested), then no group has an absolute epistemic privilege. Second, and more importantly for my purposes, he argues that deference is the wrong epistemic tool for building political movements, because deference involves taking someone's word without fully grasping why it's right. Without reasoned conviction, Hannon claims solidarity can become fragile and easily fractured under pressure.

This paper begins from a place of partial agreement. Moral understanding matters because it can deepen commitment and stabilize movements. It give people the language and reasons to keep advocating. But the question is whether moral understanding is really a prerequisite for solidarity. In what follows I argue that, instead of grounding solidarity, moral understanding often *emerges from it.*

To explore this possibility, I turn to a moment of crisis: AIDS activism in the late 1980s and early 90s. In particular, I focus on ACT UP!, which from its founding was a movement that did not demand shared theory before action and did not assume that everyone involved fully understood the moral terrain they were entering. And yet, ACT UP! was wildly successful in achieving its demands. Rather than beginning with a unified moral framework about healthcare, gay rights, or state responsibility, ACT UP! . began with anger, grief, urgency and, crucially, a willingness to defer to those most affected. What followed was not confusion or collapse under pressure that Hannon would predict, but one of the most effective political movements in recent history.

The history of ACT UP! suggests a different picture of solidarity than Hannon's. It suggests that action which is messy, incomplete, and collective can *generate* moral understanding over time. On this alternative view, deference is not a failure of reasoning. It is a starting point, and a scaffold. Deference is used to build nascent movements and can be outgrown as movements take shape.

**II. Criticisms of Standpoint Epistemology**

Standpoint theorists argue that deference is warranted because marginalized standpoints can have greater credibility on questions concerning one's oppression and social position. The argument that deference can be epistemically fruitful comes from two foundational claims in Standpoint theory: (i) that knowledge is socially situated and (ii) that marginalized locations can generate *epistemic advantage*. The roots of Standpoint theory can be traced back to Marx. Marx argued that workers occupy a unique position from which the coercive nature of capitalism is visible in ways it is not to those who benefit from capitalism. Feminist theorists, including Dorothy Smith, Nancy Hartsock, and Sandra Harding, in the 1970s and 80s extended this idea: if class position can shape knowledge, why not gender, race, sexuality, or disability? Smith contributed the claim that knowledge is *socially situated* – what people experience, notice, and understand is shaped by their social position because different people experience different social realities. Hartsock added to this insight the idea that marginalized locations can generate *epistemic advantage* – women's positions within reproduction and caregiving provides access to dimensions of social reality hidden from dominant perspectives. Harding and Hartsock both theorized standpoints as *achievements* arising through collective reflection and political struggle. Standpoints on their view emerge through consciousness-raising, critique, and shared political engagement. The epistemic advantage that emerges from this cultivation of standpoints means that marginalized people often have knowledge about social oppression and power structures that deserve special weight or deference from outsiders.

Saint-Croix (2026), for example, argues that the deference that Standpoint theory recommends is the beginning of epistemically excellent inquiry. In her view, one can defer to another person's judgment while continuing to investigate the reasons and mechanisms behind that judgment. Saint-Croix's picture deference's role in inquiry suggests that standpoint theory in general recommends inquiry that is attentive and investigative of who is an epistemic authority on a given topic.

On the flip side, authors including Tilton & Toole (2026), Taiwo (2023), and Hannon (2025) argue against deference epistemology due, in part, to the worry that deference can discourage independent learning and promote epistemic laziness. Specifically, Hannon argues that calls for deference to the marginalized should be rejected because such deference hinders the development of moral understanding.

Moral understanding, as Hannon appeals to it, is capacity for understanding *why* a moral proposition is true, and as such it is a capacity that (i) comes in degrees, and (ii) can vary in depth, breadth, and coherence. Moral understanding can be achieved in a variety of ways: via perception, first-personal experience, and moral reasoning (Sliwa (2017), Hill (2016)).[i] Hannon defines deference as "the willingness to accept or believe what another person says without independently verifying the claim.

Deference cannot impart moral understanding because moral understanding is a capacity for consistent, apt moral judgment. Deference, so defined, in no way develops this capacity. Since uncritical deference promotes epistemic laziness, according to Hannon, it does not in any way contribute to a person's ability to *reliably act rightly* and *effectively justify their actions* to others, which straightforwardly impedes political solidarity and coalition building. Hannon describes this succinctly:

> …[deference] creates barriers to the deep understanding and conviction needed to sustain effective political movements…when allies rely on deference, they may fail to internalize the moral reasons behind calls for change, leaving them ill-equipped to persuade others or articulate the cause in broader terms. This can result in a fragile form of solidarity that collapses under pressure…

But a standpoint theorist might reasonably respond to Hannon's criticism that one should not *blindly* defer. Deference should be accompanied by efforts to understand the perspectives of marginalized individuals. In other words, people still have to take responsibility for "doing the work" to develop their moral understanding while deferring. However, Hannon doesn't think this truly solves the problem. He provides the PETER PROBLEM.

> PETER PROBLEM: Suppose Peter, a cis man, and his female roommates are interviewing a new potential roommate. After the interview is done, Peter's roommates nix that candidate because of sexist behavior, but Peter didn't notice anything. Assume deference is appropriate in the first instance, the standpoint reply suggests that Peter should defer but not suspend his own reasoning entirely – he should engage his housemates to better understand the concerns, seek out feminist literature, and reflect critically on his assumptions and understanding. Suppose he does all that and a similar situation arises months later: Peter's housemates again judge an applicant's behavior as sexist, but Peter sees nothing objectionable. He has made good-faith efforts to improve his moral understanding, yet his judgment still diverges.

The purpose of the PETER PROBLEM is to show that insistence on "doing the work" does not really address Hannon's underlying complaint about deference. Because, on Hannon's interpretation of Standpoint theory, anytime a disagreement arises, the privileged individual is

expected to defer. So, the moral understanding that Peter has developed is inert with respect to his decision-making.

However, if now that Peter has developed his own moral understanding, he should rely on it in the second case, then why shouldn't he develop his own moral understanding and rely on it in the first place, instead of deferring? Hannon concludes that:

> …This suggests that, despite attempts to balance deference with independent moral reasoning, standpoint-based deference would remain deeply asymmetrical. Those without the relevant social location are expected to defer, even after making serious efforts to understand the issue for themselves."

Hannon supplements his argument with Dishaw's (2024) disengagement problem. When faced with conflicting testimony from marginalized individuals, attempting to defer to both perspectives equally will cause an impossible position. The only thing to do in this case that is rational is to suspend judgment. Conflicting testimony for the deferrer results in judgment suspension "because others have not settled the matter for him." In these instances, suspension of judgment means standing in solidarity with no one.

Hannon concludes that genuine politically viable solidarity cannot rest on deference. It requires active engagement with the experiences and perspectives of the marginalized, whichemphasizes empathy and mutual (and moral) understanding. Without this we cannot build strong and sustainable movements because the moral core of the movement will be too weak. According to Hannon, even if the movement is built on some moral knowledge that is taken for granted, everyone supporting that movement has to be plugged into that moral knowledge in a comprehensive and active way.

## III. Rejoinder: Deference as a Scaffold

Hannon's picture of solidarity feels like the ideal: a group of people who both act together and reflectively understand *why* they act. There is incredible power to be had in movements like those he envisions, which are grounded in shared reasons, mutual comprehension, and moral clarity. But here I'll argue that these ideals mislead because they're mistaken for prerequisites. The question isn't whether Hannon's kind of solidarity is valuable – surely it is. It's whether it's *required*, especially of nascent communities, and whether movements have to wait for moral understanding to catch up before acting.

Here, I think, the picture weakens. When we turn from philosophical models to actual political history, what we find is something much messier and more urgent. Movements rarely begin with shared theory or understanding. They begin with uneven commitments, conflicting perspectives, and a sense that something must change. Supposing that is right, deference seems to play a different role than Hannon suggests. It is not indicative of a failure of moral reasoning, but is a way of acting together *prior* to full understanding. To demonstrate this concretely, I'll turn to a case where epistemic reflection was subsumed by the urgency of need.

### a. ACT UP! and the urgency of action

By the late 1980s, the AIDS crisis had become impossible to ignore, and yet equally politically neglected. Thousands were dying and the institutions tasked with responding – government agencies, pharmaceutical companies, medical establishments – were managerial at best, and deliberately slow, indifferent, or openly hostile at worst. For many of the communities affected, the situation was existential.

So, ACT UP! emerged – not as a carefully theorized movement, but as a radically democratic, action-oriented coalition. Its organizing principle was strikingly minimal: "**direct action to end the AIDS crisis"**. There was no unified moral framework and no requirement that participants first align on why the crisis mattered or what grounded their obligations. What they had instead was more volatile: a moral clarity on the injustice of the situation that animated their anger and willingness to act.

This becomes especially clear when we contrast ACT UP! with the Gay Men's Health Crisis (GMHC), the NYC AIDS organization which dominated advocacy in the early 1980s. GMHC, established in 1982, was focused on health and social services for HIV-positive individuals. GMHC filled a critical social support gap that many experienced due to lack of family support and failures of public health and disability funding. GMHC at the time of its founding was the first large AIDS service organization and became a core model for professionalized nonprofit care. It functioned as crisis counseling, a buddy system, and social support for dying young people who lacked family support.

GMHC was centrally structured, and decision-making authority was **top-down**. The board of directors and paid professional staff made decisions oriented at coordination with hospitals, funders, and government agencies. Inside of GMHC, people living with AIDS were beneficiaries of support and often volunteers, but not consistently the primary decision-makers. GMHC's animating value was that "people with AIDS deserved care, dignity, and support – *even when the state abandoned them*". This resulted in their social services orientation which emphasized life affirmation, stigma and shame reduction, and isolation reduction. This orientation gave rise to a fundamental goal to make people with AIDS ***legible to power***.

This implicitly required a kind of respectability politics – seeking support and non-alienation from philanthropies and government agencies, emphasizing responsibility, care, and citizenship of all individuals in the US including gay men, and framing AIDS as a public health emergency not a moral failure.[ii] Due to these inflexible features of the animating principles of GMHC, they found themselves consistently conciliatory to powerful institutions, no matter the opinions of people living with AIDS. They limited the sexual explicitness of their public messaging and militant confrontation with medical, religious, and governmental institutions.

This orientation came from what I will call GMHC's *principles-to-praxis* model – their guiding principles, founded on an argument for why they held those principles (moral understanding) is what grounded their solidarity with and support of AIDS victims. The testimony of AIDS victims as to what they wanted out of advocacy groups did little to change their principles because that testimony was seen as irrational – direct action and structural

critique did little, according to the board of directors, to provide social services to as many HIV+ people as they could.

The result of this principles-first advocacy was both a stability, but also a kind of constraint. Because when principles come first, they can insulate themselves from challenge. Testimony – especially when it demands confrontation or disruption – can be filtered, moderated, or dismissed as impractical. This is especially vivid when the principles from which the advocacy is being done constrain what solutions you imagine to be possible. And in the context of the AIDS crisis, that directly translated into channeling political energy into managing suffering.

Larry Kramer famously resigned from GMHC in 1983 due to frustrations with the failure of the organization to move the needle politically. The core tensions between ACT UP! activists and GHMC staffers was that GMHC had "depoliticized" the AIDS crisis. According to ACT UP! Activists, GMHC was structured to avoid the root causes of suffering and normalize privatized care. As a result, they thought GMHC had a net negative political effect- It had made state neglect survivable rather than unacceptable. As a member of GMHC and later ACT UP!, Kramer describes the difference between the organizations:

> The big difference between the two organizations was this – I was determined that whatever got started [ACT UP!], it would not be structured because that's what GMHC had become. Everything had to have a job description and approval by this, and approval by that. And I didn't want that. So, we went the other way. I often describe [ACT UP!] as democratic to a fault. And when people came and said, we want to start this, or we want to start that – fine.

What Kramer describes in detail might be abstracted into describing ACT UP! as an experiment in radical democracy with big tent politics. ACT UP! had only an organizing committee for dispensing funds and an affinity group structure[iii] that were committed to a single principle of unity: "Direct Action to End the AIDS crisis". This structure was directly opposed to that of GMHC – rather than expertise being credentialed, in ACT UP! expertise was experiential.

ACT UP!'s goal was to be accountable in its operations to the lived experiences of its rank-and-file members, particularly those living with AIDS. Call this radically democratic approach a *praxis-to-principles* model. From this foundational deference to people with AIDS as political agents, and not just clients, the question was how to craft direct action that would push for those demands on a structural level. For example, instead of supplementing caregiving where nuclear families had failed, ACT UP! explicitly politicized kinship relationships – calling for structural changes to healthcare access like allowing hospital visitation rights to non-family members and legal recognition of caregivers that were not biologically related to the person with AIDS.

This led directly to the huge simultaneity of response that Kramer describes. This radically democratic structure led ACT UP! to many substantial wins that have changed the face of public medicine and social services today. Those achievements were largely made through direct action including direct action to close down FDA headquarters in Maryland in 1998,

protesting at the NY Stock Exchange over AZT prices, and well-known "die-ins" across New York City.

This meant that ACT UP! was, at its core, not a consensus-based, structural power-dependent movement like GMHC. It did not push all of its members into only one analysis of the current moment or one strategy for a solution to the crisis. ACT UP! realized the aspirations of its members in action and concrete demands first. Maxine Wolfe, an organizer for ACT UP! describes this strategy directly: "If you do action first, your theory will emerge, because you have to make decisions that coheres with your values." Schulman adds "…if you do theory first you all end up polarized, and you are fighting with each other, and nothing's actually at stake."

Instead of starting with theory, ACT UP! eschewed any deep theory for successful action. Instead of centralized authority, it embraced decentralization. Instead of credentialed expertise, it foregrounded experiential knowledge. And crucially, it did not require that everyone involved *fully understand* the moral stakes before participating. If anything, it assumed the opposite. That volunteers and activists who did not have AIDS would not fully understand the stakes, and their understanding would grow from a deference to the lived experience of AIDS victims to a moral understanding through their participation and relationships built within ACT UP!. This allowed the weight of the crisis and the success of the strategies to develop and be witnessed organically.

**b. Deference in practice**

Taking the lessons that Kramer and others offer from ACT UP! invites an enticing alternative to Hannon's pessimism about deference. Unlike what he claims, movements and the solidarity that knit them together give rise to moral understanding and depth of values. Recall, Hannon's argument is that moral understanding is necessary for true solidarity, which in turn is necessary for effective political coalition building. The flip-side of that argument is that deference, which requires no moral understanding, but rather just deferring to the experiential expertise of others, undermines effective coalition building and thus is not an adequate basis for political momentum.

However, the AIDS crisis is an epoch within American history where the most successful political momentum came from a group founded distinctly not on moral understanding, or a set of agreed upon values. Understanding ACT UP! as a *praxis-to-principles* movement is essentially to understand it as a group committed to the emergence of their principles out of deference to the direction their members wanted to take the group.

Within ACT UP!, deference to other members was foundational – across differences in experience, knowledge, and vulnerability. People living with AIDS articulated experiences and demands; others creatively organized around them. Different affinity groups pursued different strategies, often without consensus. Schulman documents significant amounts of disagreement, fragmentation, even conflict in her Oral History of AC TUP!. Yet, the radically democratic core of the organization held strong. People were free within ACT UP! to pursue the projects that motivated them, which birthed certain unifying projects and allowed projects to gain momentum naturally.

ACT UP's mission was in some ways initially unified  bya willingness to *take seriously* the claims of others, even when one did not yet grasp the moral understanding behind them. This deference grounded an orientation toward action under conditions of practical uncertainty. Larry Kramer captures this spirit in describing ACT UP!'s structure: if someone had an idea—an action, a protest, a demand—they could pursue it. Others might join, or not. There was no requirement that everyone agree in advance, or understand fully what was at stake, their theory followed practice.

This is a striking inversion of Hannon's picture. Instead of moral understanding grounding solidarity, solidarity becomes the site *where* moral understanding develops. Participants act together, reflect together, and revise together, and over time, their commitments deepen and reasons and moral underpinnings emerge or become clearer.  But none of that is required at the outset, or of any initial coalescence of solidarity. And directly in opposition to Hannon's predictions, this deference to the testimony of AIDS victims didn't undermine ACT UP!'s effectiveness. The movement achieved concrete, lasting changes: accelerating FDA drug approval processes, lowering drug prices, expanding access to experimental treatments, and establishing needle exchange programs. These weren't fragile victories. They reshaped public health policy.

So, here's the tension. If Hannon is right, movements built on deference should be unstable, shallow, and vulnerable to collapse. But ACT UP! suggests precisely the opposite: that movements and the people that comprise them can be both deferential *and* powerful. In other words, they can be epistemically imperfect and politically effective.

**c. From prerequisite to outcome**

What this review of AIDS crisis advocacy suggests is not that moral understanding is irrelevant. On the contrary, it matters deeply—especially for sustaining movements over time, for expanding them, and for articulating their goals to broader audiences. However, moral understanding is not a *precondition* of solidarity. Rather solidarity can be scaffolded by deference.

Seen this way, Hannon's argument is useful because it makes a common temporal mistake: that we must make the intellectual achievement of moral understanding before we can be effective partners for solidarity in any moral action.  ACT UP!—and many movements like it —reverses this order. Action under conditions of partial understanding generates the very capacities Hannon thinks are missing. Deference, on this view, is not a substitute for moral reasoning. Deference is a way of *getting into motion* when reasoning is incomplete. It is an epistemic tool that can be relied on when asymmetries in knowledge and experience make full agreement unlikely, if not impossible. As people act together, that scaffold is revised, reinforced, and even partially dismantled as understanding grows. Sure moral understanding strengthens solidarity, but it does not have to precede it. Sometimes, it is provisional solidarity that makes even partial moral understanding possible in the first place.

**IV. Conclusion**

Let's return to where we started. Hannon says that deference cannot ground solidarity because it cannot generate the kind of moral understanding that truly committed, durable movements require. There is substance to that concern. Movements must acquire depth, and so they need people who can explain themselves, defend their commitments, and stay aligned when things get difficult. However, what I have tried to show is that this picture is incomplete because it asks movements and individuals to emerge at full maturity.

Hannon grounds in this claim in the PETER PROBLEM, where individual instances of deference on moral knowledge are at odds with developing moral understanding, and Dishaw's DISENGAGEMENT PROBLEM, where deference can lead to political alienation when trying to defer to two or more marginalized individuals are on different sides of an issue. However, looking at actual political practice, under conditions of asymmetry and crisis, we see something quite different. There is the opposite of disengagement, instead people take up actions and subcommittees within ACT UP! that move them, and leave the rest. We see coalitions built on partial trust, rather than shared theory. The coalitions built in ACT UP! were often founded on a willingness to take the claims of others seriously and functioned as an invitation to build and reshape communal understanding. What we see, in other words, is deference doing real political work.

ACT UP! is not an anomaly in political history., Instead, it is a vivid illustration of the how various effective political movements throughout history have developed. ACT UP! hopefully demonstrates that movements are not born fully formed, with coherent moral frameworks and unified visions. They are built in motion: through disagreement, experimentation, and action that outpaces explanation. In that process of movement building, people begin to understand through shared struggle, rather than in abstraction. Moral understanding, on this picture, is *produced*, as opposed to bypassed by deference.

This reframing is important because it changes how we think about the risks of deference. For Hannon, deference threatens to hollow out solidarity, leaving participants without the resources to sustain their commitments. However, when deference is understood as a provisional strategy, as a kind of epistemic scaffold rather than a final stance, then it becomes a tool for coordination under uncertainty. It functions as a way of enabling collective action when full understanding is not yet available.

As movements succeed, or fail, participants revise their commitments, deepen their understanding, and build new frameworks. The scaffold of deference can be adjusted, or partially dismantled. What begins as deference can become understanding, because partial alignment can and does develop into the robust solidarity Hannon rightly values. This doesn't mean that deference is without any danger. It can slide into uncritical acceptance, asymmetry, and disengagement – as criticisms of identity politics and ally culture rightfully demonstrate.[iv] Deference can, in some contexts, obscure responsibility rather than distribute it. However, these are not arguments for abandoning deference altogether. They are arguments for getting clearer about *when* and *how* it should be used.

Deference, ultimately, is not the enemy of solidarity, or always its foundation. It is something more provisional. A way of acting together before we fully know why, and a way of building the conditions under which understanding can emerge at all. If that is right, then the task isn't to choose between deference and understanding, but instead to track the shifting relationship between them. What is critical to the success of political solidarity is to continually engage with the question of how acting together *makes* understanding possible.

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[i] Whether the achievement of moral understanding comes from moral reasoning only or can be achieved in other ways, specifically via moral testimony, is central to the debate between Sliwa and Hills. I will sidestep this, as Hannon assumes only what is in agreement between the two.

[ii] Most starkly what they were trying to combat in messaging was the original framing, taken up by the Regan administration, was that AIDS was "gay cancer" – the result of living an amoral life.

[iii] ACT UP! is well remembered for its Monday meetings at the NYC LGBTQ center. However, critical to the organizational structure was that affinity groups never had to actually bring their proposed actions to the floor of the Monday meetings. They could do direct action and ACT UP! would still provide legal support. This structure evolved out of suspicion that there was heavy infiltration of ACT UP! by the police, which was later substantiated in redacted documents published by Schulman (2021).

[iv] For an excellent example, see Jodi Dean's (2021) *Comrade*.